

Edema

Putting your feet up

Make sure your feet are higher than your hips when you are in a resting position.

» What, when, and how often?

Edema is otherwise known as water or fluid retention—and it causes swelling and puffiness in your cells. Edema can be partly responsible for a more flushed, plumped-up complexion on your face, but also for swollen ankles, feet, wrists, and fingers. Around half of all pregnant women suffer from edema at some stage in their pregnancy, particularly in the third trimester.

» What causes it

In order to carry nutrients efficiently to your baby, your blood volume increases by up to one-third during pregnancy. However, not all this increase in volume is made up of extra red blood cells—a large proportion of it is fluid. When the fluid enters the cells in your body, it causes them to swell. Sometimes—especially when you've been stationary for a long period of time, or toward the end of the day, or if the weather is especially hot—the fluid pools in your cells, and this causes the excess swelling.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Most women will experience some normal swelling during the course of their pregnancy, usually in the extremities (fingers, hands, toes, feet, and ankles). If the swelling is excessive, consult your doctor.

» What can I do?

Drink plenty of fluid since this helps to flush excess fluid from your body (although it may seem counterintuitive to do so). Eat a healthy diet and try to gain weight steadily throughout your pregnancy. Exercise regularly and appropriately for your pregnancy stage. If you notice that your extremities are swelling, keep them moving—make circles with your wrists and ankles and give your toes and fingers a stretch. Avoid too being stationary for long stretches of time—get up and walk around every 30 minutes or so to prevent fluid from pooling in your legs. When you rest, try to make sure your feet are higher than your hips.

Numbness in hands

» What, when, and how often?

The very odd sensation of your hand going numb, along with pain in your thumb and first two fingers, may be the result of carpal tunnel syndrome. This condition can occur usually in the second or third trimester of pregnancy and affects around 50 percent of pregnant women. Carpal tunnel syndrome tends to run in families; and you're likely to get it again if you've had it in a previous pregnancy. It occurs most often in the dominant hand (so your right hand if you're right-handed).

» What causes it?

Your pregnancy hormones increase the amount of fluid circulating in your system. When that fluid pools in your wrists (often at night when you're stationary), causing swelling, it can put pressure on your median nerve, which runs down your arm into your hand. This then leads to

numbness and a pins-and-needles sensation in the fingers of your hand. You'll be more susceptible to the condition if you are overweight or are carrying more than one baby.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

If carpal tunnel syndrome is the reason for your numbness, there are no harmful effects for your baby or your pregnancy, but you may find it hard to use your hand properly—in particular you'll probably find that you have a weak grip.

» What can I do?

Aside from eating healthily and performing wrist exercises (somewhat like the ankle exercises you might try for swollen ankles), all you can do is wait it out. Most cases of carpal tunnel syndrome will pass within a few months of your baby's birth. If you find the numbness lingers, you may need to have surgery to relieve the pressure on your median nerve. Your doctor might give you a wrist support from to help support your hand.

Nasal problems

» What, when, and how often?

Around one-third of all pregnant women experience nasal problems during pregnancy, commonly beginning around the middle of the second trimester and lasting until birth. Typically, the problems are frequent nosebleeds, increased nasal congestion, and snoring.

» What causes them?

Nasal congestion and snoring is caused by increased estrogen in your system, which causes a proliferation of mucus in your nasal passages (you may also find you develop blocked ears). Nosebleeds become more frequent because the walls of the tiny capillaries in your nose thin out and are more liable to breaking.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Nosebleeds that don't stop need medical attention, because they could be a sign of a circulation problem; and very loud, very prolonged snoring may be a sign of gestational diabetes. Other than those circumstances, nasal problems are just a harmless side effect of pregnancy.

» What can I do?

Talk to your doctor to make sure that what you're experiencing is normal. If there is cause for concern, your doctor will do more checks.

Blurred vision

» What, when, and how often?

Eye problems are extremely common during pregnancy, most noticeably many women experience blurring in their vision. Dry eyes and temporary loss of peripheral vision may also occur.

» What causes it?

The cells in your skin start to swell with increased fluid during pregnancy—and the same happens in your eyeballs. This causes the lens in your eye to thicken and distort, blurring your vision. It's possible that the effect is exacerbated because progesterone levels in your body, which cause your muscles to become more lax, may have the same softening effect on your cornea.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Blurred vision can be a sign of preeclampsia (flashes in your eyes, too), so it's very important that you let your doctor know if you experience any changes to your eyesight. Most of the time, though, it's just another side effect of pregnancy.

» What can I do?

Keep up your fluid intake to try to minimize fluid retention in your cells. Your vision should return to normal after birth, but it may take several weeks. Some women experience permanent changes to their eyesight, so if you're still having sight problems six weeks after you've had your baby, visit your optician.